

Area of Study 1D – Buddhism

Overview

This area of study comprises a study in depth of Buddhism as a lived religion within the United Kingdom and throughout the world, and its beliefs and teachings on life, specifically within families, and with regard to matters of life and death.

There are four sections: Buddhist Beliefs, Marriage and the Family, Living the Buddhist Life and Matters of Life and Death.

The significance and importance of the various beliefs, issues and practices to Buddhists today should be explored throughout the sections. This should include reference to how scripture informs a Buddhist's understanding of the topics and how approaches to the issues are underpinned by philosophical arguments and ethical theory as applicable.

Students will be expected to study Buddhism within the context of the wider British society, the religious traditions of which are, in the main, Christian. Students should compare and contrast the areas of belief and practice within Buddhism with Christianity as outlined in the content below.

- Beliefs about the afterlife and their significance (1.5)*
- The practice and significance of worship (3.6)*

Students should recognise that Buddhism is one of the many religions and world views in Great Britain, which include Hinduism, Judaism, Islam, Sikhism and non-religious views such as Humanism and atheism. This knowledge may be applied throughout the assessment of the specified content.

Students should compare and contrast the areas of ethics and/or philosophy within Buddhism and non-religious views as outlined in the content below.

Students should also recognise that within Buddhism there may be more than one perspective in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed. Common and divergent views within Buddhism in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed should be included throughout, including reference to Theravada and Mahayana traditions.

Students should have an understanding of:

1.1	The life of the Buddha: the nature and history of the events in the life of the Buddha and why they are important to Buddhists today, including ancestry, birth, princely life, marriage and the Four Sights, with reference to Buddhavamsa XXVI; the enlightenment of the Buddha and founding of the Sangha.
1.2	Dhamma: the nature and different meaning of dhamma (dependent origination /conditionality); the nature and importance of paticca-samuppada and the Three Marks of Existence, including reference to the Story of Nagasena and the Chariot in the Milinda Panha; suffering (dukkha), no fixed self (anicca) and soul or essence (anatta); the implications of belief in dhamma for Buddhists today.
1.3	First Noble Truth, including reference to the Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta: the nature of dukkha; Buddhist teachings about suffering; the different types of suffering as pain, fabrication and change; the importance of suffering for Buddhists today.
1.4	Second Noble Truth, including reference to Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta: the nature of samudaya (the root of suffering); Buddhist teachings about the causes of suffering, including the Sermon at Benares; the Three Poisons and how they are represented in the Wheel of Life; divergent understandings of the Wheel of Life, with reference to Theravada and Mahayana Buddhism.
1.5*	Third Noble Truth, including reference to the Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta: the nature of nirodha and the cessation of tanha; Buddhist teachings about the ending of desire; the nature of the cycle of samsara; different understandings of nibbana and enlightenment and their importance for Buddhists today.
1.6	Fourth Noble Truth, including reference to the Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta: the nature of the Middle Way (magga); Buddhist teachings about the Eightfold Path leading to nibbana. The Threefold Way: the nature, purpose and importance of sila (ethics), samadhi (meditation) and panna (wisdom); divergent understandings of the importance Eightfold Path and the Threefold Way for Buddhist life today.
1.7	Human life: divergent Buddhist understandings of the nature and importance of the Five Khandas (aggregates), including the Khandha Sutta; divergent Buddhist understandings of the nature and importance of sunnata and tathagatagarbha (Buddha-nature); divergent Buddhist understandings of the nature and importance of Arahant and Bodhisattva Ideals; divergent Buddhist understandings of the nature and history of Buddhahood and the Pure Land.
1.8	Buddhist ethical teachings: divergent Buddhist understandings of the nature, purpose and importance of kamma, including Dhammapada 181–187 and the Khuddakapatha, merit and rebirth, karuna (compassion), metta (loving kindness), pancha sila (the Five Precepts) and the paramitas (Six Perfections); the divergent applications of each of these ethical teachings in Buddhist life today.